

## Recommended buys

The very best products you can buy right now spanning 10 categories including sound cards, projectors, IEMs



## WD Acquires SanDisk!

If you haven't heard already, Western Digital acquired SanDisk for a whopping \$19 billion!  
<http://dgit.in/Nv15ai>

Agent 001

### Gaming laptop for 42K

I am big fan of you and the whole of your team. And I want your help in buying a gaming laptop under 42,000 INR. Please give me as many options as possible in the form of a ranked list in order based on their gaming performance if possible. But please give their prices also in India. I have tried a lot of ways to find the right choice but I ended up getting more confused. You are my last hope.

– Avinash Kadam

**A** Instead of coming up with a list of our own, we decided to help out Bobby in generating this list on his own. We wanted to “teach him how to fish”. So we asked Bobby to look at various review sites and told him how search filters work on these sites so that he could short list a bunch of laptops based on his criteria which we helped refine. He came up with about 11 laptops of which a majority of them matched his criterion i.e. a sufficiently powerful CPU for gaming and a good discrete graphics card.



Most of the options in his budget sported 5th Generation Intel Core i5 processors, the highest performing SKU of which turned out to be the Core i5-5200U which is quite sufficient for gaming and has a turbo clock of 2.7 GHz at peak load. When it came to storage space and memory, most of the laptops had a 1 TB hard drive and 4 GB of RAM. So the final parameter left was the graphics card. While the majority of the options came with the NVIDIA 820M which is a Fermi based GPU with 96 CUDA cores clocked somewhere between 719 MHz to 954 MHz depending on the model. One lone ranger came with a NVIDIA 920M which can either be based on the older Fermi architecture or the newer Kepler if you're

lucky. Though, either SKU should be good enough since they both feature 384 CUDA cores with the one based on Kepler being clocked slightly lower and thus will run slightly cooler while delivering the same amount of performance.

At the end of a really long email thread, we recommended Bobby to go for the Asus X555LJ-XX130D which not only featured the Core i5-5200U and the NVIDIA 920M. The only downside is the 15.6-inch display which has a resolution of 1366 x 768 and that's what all models had. You really can't get more for the price without making compromises in some aspect or the other. Aside from the ASUS laptop, two other laptops stood out from the crowd, both of which happened to be from HP – the HP Compaq 15-s104TX and the HP 15-r007tx. These are essentially the same laptop based on the hardware.

### Upgrade suggestions

Hey guys, here's my PC configuration:

- **Processor:** Intel Core i7 920 @2.67GHz
  - **Motherboard:** MSI X58 Pro-E (USB 2.0)
  - **Storage:** Samsung 850 Pro 256Gb SSD + WD 2Tb HDD
  - **RAM:** Corsair 8GB DDR3 @534 MHz
  - **Graphics Card:** XFX Radeon HD 5750
  - **SMPS:** VIP 600W
  - **Optical drive:** Samsung DVD RW
  - **Cabinet:** Cooler Master CM 690 II
  - **OS:** Windows 7 Ultimate (x64)
  - **Addons:** PCIe USB 3.0 card, Ex-HDD
- A. Please suggest the best motherboard available for my processor, up to '20K
  - B. Please suggest a good UPS for my config. I don't have frequent power cut problems & will buy it for the safety of my PC components & HDD data.
  - C. Please suggest top 3 mid-range graphics cards for my config. For serious gaming, is it better to install a single amazing graphics card or two good graphics cards in Crossfire/ SLI ?
  - D. Is my RAM configuration good enough for high-end gaming ?

– Manish Modi

**A** Hey Manish,

- A. Unless you're experiencing some problem with the existing motherboard, it's advisable to not go for a new motherboard. And the X58 boards are already

EOL so it's quite unlikely that you'll find a replacement online or in stores. You're limited to whatever they have in hand.

- B. Your current configuration runs up around 390 W or so. So you'll need a 1000 VA UPS. APC UPS are known for their quality and since your power supply doesn't require a pure sinewave output, the BR1000G-IN should be sufficient.
- C. There's another question that needs to be answered here. Is this serious gamer price conscious? There have been



incidences when an SLI configuration would provide a lot better performance than a single flagship card but there are quite a few games which don't work properly on multi-GPU configurations and you have to wait for a driver update for it to work. Since you can't predict which game might have an issue with multi-GPU configurations, there is a possibility that you might have to disable a GPU every once in a while to play some game or the other. As of now, two 960s in SLI are better than a 980. The problem arises when textures are huge and require more video memory. SLI doesn't effectively double video memory so that remains an issue. You didn't mention the price point that you are looking at. So it would be best to go for a GTX 960 or GTX 970 based on how much you game. Two GTX 960s are also good but you might want to upgrade your power supply in that case.

- D. Again, your RAM should be sufficient if you reduce draw distance in games if they end up eating too much RAM. But then again, if you're into simulators like ARMA where a higher draw distance gives you the tactical advantage then you might want to increase RAM as well. **E**